

This paper is an ongoing project to tell the full history of Arlington's form of government. If you come across this and have any suggestions, ideas, or information to add to the paper please email Grace Hjerpe at grjwhite8@gmail.com and she will make sure to credit you in the paper.

As I am able to find new information on the topic, I plan on updating this document. For the most up-to-date version of this paper, please visit:
https://drive.google.com/drive/folders/17dmyq8QJTH4I0AKFhHpuWMkBM1V8dB__?usp=sharing

Lingering Inquiries - Right now, the following unanswered questions are at the forefront of my mind. Should anyone have knowledge of them, or have ideas on how to further research them, please let me know. Other feedback is welcomed as well, but my focus currently is on these questions:

1. In my research, I found census records which seemed to indicate that there were 5 Black members of the county board during the 1870s and 1880s: William A. Rowe, John B. Syphax, Travis B. Pinn, John W. Pendleton, and Tibbett Allen. While there is a lot written about Mr. Rowe, I haven't been able to find much information on the other four men. Who were these other men? Are there people with knowledge of them alive today, or are there historical sources that might hold more information on their lives.
2. Through the Arlington County Elections office, I have obtained a precinct map that would have been used for the 1930 change in government referendum. Seeing as four of eleven precincts voted to keep district representation, is there a pattern in the neighborhoods of the four precincts? Anyone with demographic knowledge of 1920s-30s Arlington neighborhoods is encouraged to reach out.
3. Around 1939, Arlington County changed from simultaneous election of all five board members to staggered elections. What was the reason for this? What sparked the movement?
4. The 1974 Case *Vollin v. Arlington County Electoral Board*. I have read about the case, but have yet to find any transcripts from the case or the testimony. All I have is from secondhand accounts. Do more detailed transcripts exist? Anyone with access to legal databases is encouraged to search for more information.
5. Additional change of government movements. I know there have been at least a few attempts to change back to district representation in the past 90 years, but have not read much about them. Anyone with knowledge of such attempts is encouraged to reach out.

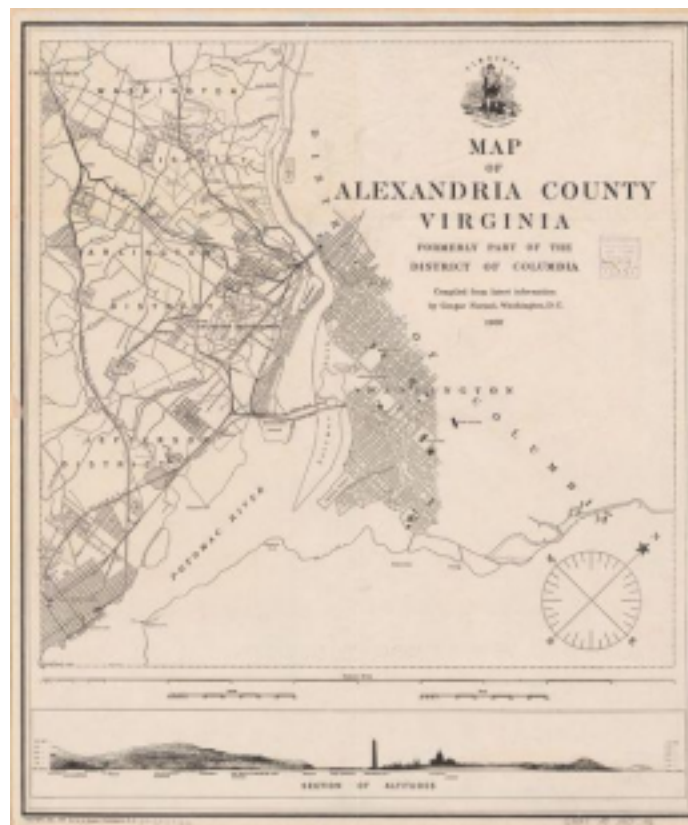
A History of Representation on the Arlington County Board, 1870-Present

1870-1930 Magisterial Districts

The History of Arlington County's government starts in 1870, the first year when the city of Alexandria split off from what was then called Alexandria County. In addition to constitutional officers such as the Treasurer and Sheriff, which were elected by the whole county, Alexandria County was governed by a three-member Magisterial Board of Supervisors.

Each member of the board was elected by the residents of a Magisterial District; none were elected at-large. The names of the Districts were Washington, Arlington, and Jefferson, and the boundaries of each District were drawn East to West, as shown in a 1907 map of the county below.

Figure 1: A Map containing the borders of Alexandria County Magisterial Districts. Made by Gregor Noetzel and G. G. Boteler, 1907¹



¹Source: <https://www.loc.gov/resource/g3883a.ct009226/>

In 1870, Alexandria County had roughly equal numbers of Black and White residents², and Black communities were concentrated in the southern part of the county in the Jefferson Magisterial District. Between 1871 and 1887, residents of the Jefferson District elected a Black County Board Member on 10 occasions out of 11 recorded elections. The first such member, William A. Rowe, was Alexandria County's first black police officer. After moving his residence, the Honorable William A. Rowe also served as Arlington Magisterial District's Board Member from 1879 to 1883.

Table 1 has a list of Alexandria County Magisterial Board members from 1871 until 1888. The names of black Arlingtonians who served are highlighted.

Table 1: Name of Alexandria County Magisterial Board Members by District, 1871-1888³

1871	H. Dwight Smith William A. Rowe Edward Deeble
1872	John B. Syphax William A. Rowe Henry W. Fehrey
December 1872	H. Dwight Smith William A. Rowe Henry W. Fehrey
March 1873	Lott W. Crocker William A. Rowe Henry W. Fehrey
April 1873	Francis D. Schutt William A. Rowe Henry W. Fehrey
December 1873	Francis D. Schutt William A. Rowe Samuel Titus
1874	Francis D. Schutt William A. Rowe Gilbert Vandenberg
1875-1876	Francis D. Schutt William A. Rowe Gilbert Vandenberg
1877-1878	William H. Robinson William A. Rowe Charles W. Payne William A. Rowe Costello
1879-1880	Travis B. Pinn ⁴ Francis G. Schutt William A. Rowe Travis B. Pinn

1881-1882	Christopher Costello Perkins W. Squier John W. Pendleton ⁵ Christopher
1883-1884	
1885-1886	George W. Veitch Richard W. Johnston John D. Payne 1887-1888 Horatio Ball Tibbett Allen ⁶ A. B. Grunwell

² Footnote 5 “The Electoral History of That Part of Alexandria County Now Known as Arlington County, 1870-1920” from the Office of Frank O’Leary

https://vote.arlingtonva.us/files/assets/vote/elections/electionresults/pre-1920_candidate_history.pdf

³ Source for names: “The Electoral History of That Part of Alexandria County Now Known as Arlington County, 1870-1920” from the Office of Frank O’Leary

⁴ Source: 1880 US Census document, Appendix 1

⁵ Source: 1880 US Census Document, Appendix 2

⁶ Source: 1880 US Census Document, Appendix 3

While Alexandria County still had a by-district system for its county board from 1889-1930, the board became and remained all white for the duration of this system. After 1888, the circumstances became so hostile to black candidates for local office that no black candidates were recorded as running for the county board again until after 1930. The last black man to serve on the Magisterial Board, Tibbett Allen, was the first Senior Warden of Arlington Lodge #58, a long-running black Free Masons organization which still exists today⁷.

1930 Change of Government Referendum

In 1930, Arlington County, so named in 1920 so as to distinguish itself further from the City of Alexandria, held a referendum on 3 questions of governance structure. The first question was whether to change the structure of governance for Arlington County, and the next question were about what kind of government to change to, in the case that voters did vote for a change. The questions were put on the ballot as laid out in Figure 2.

Figure 2: Order of Questions on Arlington County’s Change of Governance Referendum, 1930⁸

SAMPLE BALLOT

The act under which the election is being called requires that special ballots be prepared with the following questions printed thereon:

Question 1:

Shall the county change its present form of government?

For

Against

(Strike out one)

Question 2:

In the event of such change, which form of government shall be adopted?

Modified Commission Plan

County Manager Plan

(Strike out one)

Question 3:

In the event of such change shall the governing board be elected at large or by districts?

At Large

By Districts

(Strike out one)

⁷ Source: http://arlington58.org/our_history

⁸ Source: <http://arlingtonhistoricalsociety.org/wp-content/uploads/2017/02/1958-6CtyMgr.pdf>

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There are two major factors which influenced the movement to hold this change of government referendum. One factor was that Arlington County was quickly growing from a rural county into a suburb, and many people felt an updated form of government was needed. When the Magisterial Board system was set up in 1870, the county was largely rural and had around 16,000 residents. In 1930, Arlington County's population was over 25,000, and it was growing exponentially; population growth surpassed 100% per decade over the following 20 years.

Another key motivating factor is an ugly and unfortunate truth: white backlash to Arlington's Black community organizing to field candidates for office. In 1930, several black Arlingtonians ran for office, something which had not happened for decades in the county. George Vollin, Jr. (Queen City) ran for sheriff while Mary Harris (Green Valley), Dr. Edward Morton (Hall's Hill), and C.H. Mosley (Hall's Hill) ran for the county board⁹. The threat of an integrated county government, facilitated through by-district representation, seems to have scared much of Arlington's white establishment into promoting a change to exclusively at-large representation.

Arlington's Black communities were largely concentrated in the south of the

county, so the Southern Jefferson Magisterial District was an opportunity for black representation on the county board. County-wide, however, white people made up a majority of the population, so an all at-large system was practically a guarantee of all-white representation.

Figure 3: Precinct Results from Arlington County's 1930 Change of Government Referendum

ARLINGTON VOTES FOR MANAGER RULE IN COUNTY OFFICES		ARLINGTON GOVERNMENT VOTE					
		For Change.		What Change.		At Large.	
Precincts.		Yes.	No.	Commis- sion.	County Manager.	Yes.	No.
Arlington		196	208	35	182	152	218
Ballston		174	176	82	153	143	149
Clarendon No. 1		196	94	41	185	176	82
Clarendon No. 2		324	67	45	294	275	88
Carne		132	70	29	137	115	69
Cheerlydale		223	128	69	206	136	187
East Falls Church		98	46	33	92	85	55
Glen Carlyn		49	22	15	42	42	22
Lyon Park		295	40	15	293	266	56
Rouslyn		229	60	30	217	199	74
Virginia Highlands		151	122	34	135	101	150
Totals		2,067	1,031	428	1,936	1,689	1,149

Approves Change in Form of
Government, but Two Pre-
cincts Registering No.

The Evening Star Article of November 5, 1930

⁹ Source: "BUILT BY THE PEOPLE THEMSELVES – AFRICAN AMERICAN COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT IN ARLINGTON, VIRGINIA, FROM THE CIVIL WAR THROUGH CIVIL RIGHTS" by Lindsey Bestebreurtje, page 215.

http://mars.gmu.edu/bitstream/handle/1920/11125/Bestebreurtje_gmu_0883E_11369.pdf?sequence=1&isAllowed=y

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In 1974, several Arlington residents sued the county electoral board over its at-large system of governance. Citing several precedents from other localities, the plaintiffs claimed that the at-large system by intention diluted the voting power of people of color and denied them equal access to the democratic process¹⁰. During the court case, George Vollin, then a resident of Green Valley and formerly of Queen City, testified under oath that the Ku Klux Klan drove through black neighborhoods and conducted intimidation campaigns in response to black candidates running for office. Vollin also testified that Arlington County's state delegation did not request permission for a change of government referendum until after black candidates had announced their intention to run for office. Another plaintiff, Harrison Douglas, corroborated Mr. Vollin's testimony under oath in court¹¹.

Even if one doubts racist intent on the part of white Arlingtonians in 1930, it is hard to argue against the result of at-large implementation in the county. In the 90 years since Arlington has had its current voting system, all but four county board members elected under the system have been white. After 1930, it would be more than half a century before William T. Newman was elected, breaking the all-white pattern of

county governance in 1988.

Little has changed in this pattern, even following the growth of Asian and Hispanic populations in Arlington since the 1980s. As of the writing of this piece, 3 black men, one Hispanic man, and no Asian American people have served on the Arlington County Board under the at-large system. It should also be noted that all four board members of color in the at-large era were elected in years where two county board seats were up for election, and only Christian Dorsey in 2015 managed to gain office by winning the most amount of votes, rather than the second amount of votes¹². Had William T. Neuman, Charles Monroe, or Walter Tejada ran in any other election cycle, they would have lost.

It should be noted that multi-winner elections are one method of electing diverse groups of people to local office, one example of which is the government of Cambridge, Massachusetts¹³. Arlington's staggered at-large elections only allow multiple winners once every four years, ensuring that the same electorate elects a majority of the board.

¹⁰ *Arlington's At-Large Electoral System: A Study of its History, Strengths, and Weaknesses* by Sherman W. Pratt. from Arlington Historical Society Magazine, October 1995.

¹¹ Ibid

¹² Source: Arlington County Election Results, 1920-Present from the Arlington County Elections Page. See years 1987, 1999, 2003, and 2015

<https://vote.arlingtonva.us/files/assets/vote/elections/electionresults/candidate-history.pdf>

¹³ Source: "Cambridge, MA" from Fairvote.org.

https://archive3.fairvote.org/reforms/fair-representation-voting/choice-voting/where-choice-voting-is-used/in-the-united-states/cambridge-ma/?gclid=CjwKCAjwrPCGBhALEiwAUl9X0wwjHORZTDQMkzVLYoNohKkLKGcBJ0KZOX3iqDy40pxhqLvt7HaYiRoC5SAQAvD_BwE

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End Note: Tibbett Allen

During research of this paper, the author took effort to learn more about Tibbett Allen, the last black representative on the county board during reconstruction. It was known already that Allen resigned before his term's end, which frankly looked suspicious given the change in county board make-up thereafter.

All the author could find regarding Allen's departure from the county board were two pieces in the Alexandria Gazette from 1888 mentioning the board member. The first was from the "County Court" section in the September 3rd issue reading as follows:

"A rule was issued against Tibbett Allen to show cause why he should not be removed as supervisor of roads Jefferson District on account of non-residence"¹⁴

There is no context to this court rule, and it is anyone's guess as to where this accusation came from. 1888 was the year when the US government started pushing residents out of Freedman's village, so possibly Allen was forced out of the Jefferson District through this action. This is a more charitable interpretation of the situation, as in other parts of the post-reconstruction south black public officials were forced out of office under threats of mob violence. All else that the author could find was a listing from the next month's edition announcing Allen's resignation and the appointment of Frank Hume, a former confederate soldier and the namesake for the Hume School on Arlington Ridge Road, to the seat.

The 1910 census lists Allen as living in the Arlington District of Alexandria County, supporting the notion that he moved out of the Jefferson District. Later in life, Allen and his family moved to Pittsburgh, where he died in 1922¹⁵.

The author attempted to find if Allen had any living descendants, but the last record found of any Allen descendants was a notice of the death of his daughter, Viola Allen Barksdale, in the Washington post on September 22nd, 1964. Viola moved back into the Green Valley community after living much of her life in Pittsburgh, and she died in Washington, DC. The wording of the notice suggested that no family or next of kin had been found to which to pass on any possessions.

If any reader of this document happens to have knowledge of Tibbett Allen or any living descendants, the author of this piece, Grace Hjerpe, would be interested in

¹⁴ Source: Alexandria Gazette September 3rd 1888, Appendix 4

¹⁵ Source: Allegheny County Death Certificate, Appendix 5

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hearing from you. His story may be lost to time, but Grace has not given up on learning more about the man and his service.

Appendix

1. 1880 US Census Document listing Travis B Pinn, Mixed Race resident of Jefferson Township, Alexandria County



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2. 1880 US Census document listing John W Pendleton, Black resident of Jefferson Township, Alexandria County

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COUNTY COURT.—Judge D. M. Chickester presiding.—On the application of G. W. Stegmüller and J. Bingham for new roads, rates against land owners were issued returnable at the October term.

All special policeman heretofore appointed were removed except Robert Walker.

A rule was issued against Tibbett Allen to show cause why he should not be removed as supervisor of Roads of Jefferson District on account of non-residence.

The grand jury returned true bills to the following indictments: Wm. Ridgway, attempt to murder; same, carrying concealed weapons; Robert Webb, house breaking; Fred. Walker and David Shumkins, violating the Sunday law; Chas. Butler, malicious cutting; John Jackson, James Motzer and David A. Irwin, selling liquor without license; and not true bills against Chas. Butler indicted for carrying concealed weapons and Jas. Peterson for selling liquor without a license.

Court then adjourned till Court in course.

Form T. & No. 3-202-3222.

PLACE OF DEATH
County of Allegheny

CERTIFICATE OF DEATH

Township of _____
Registration District No. _____

City of Pittsburgh **No. 12 Elmore** **St. 5** **Ward** _____

Primary Registration District No. _____
Registered No. **9242**

A. FULL NAME **Tibbett Allen.**

PERSONAL AND STATISTICAL PARTICULARS

1. SEX **Male** **2. COLOR OR RACE** **Col** **3. SINGLE, MARRIED, WIDOWED OR DIVORCED** **Married**

4. DATE OF BIRTH **June 15 1893**

5. AGE **59** **6. LESS THAN 1 day** **less than 1 day**

7. OCCUPATION **Watchman**

8. BIRTHPLACE **U.S.A.**

9. MARRIAGE OF FATHERS **Tibbett Allen**

10. BIRTHPLACE OF FATHER **U.S.A.**

11. MARRIAGE OF MOTHER **Harriet Brown**

12. BIRTHPLACE OF MOTHER **U.S.A.**

13. THE ABOVE IS TRUE TO THE BEST OF MY KNOWLEDGE.

Signature **Laura V. Allen**

Address **12 Elmore St**

14. DATE OF BIRTH OR DEATH **Dec 29 1952**

15. PLACE OF BIRTH OR DEATH **Allegheny, Penn**

16. LENGTH OF RESIDENCE (for Hospital, Sanatorium, etc.) **10 Days**

17. CAUSE OF DEATH **Cardiac Asthma (angina) Bronchitis**

18. DATE OF DEATH **Dec 31 1952**

19. PLACE OF DEATH **Home**

20. SIGNATURE OF DECEASED **John D. Davis**

21. SIGNATURE OF WITNESS **John D. Davis**

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100. SIGNATURE OF DECEASED **John D. Davis**

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6. Notice on the death of Viola Barksdale Allen, Washington Post September 24, 1964

Legal Notice 1 -- No Title
The Washington Post, Times Herald (1959-1973): Sep 22, 1964;
ProQuest Historical Newspapers: The Washington Post

LEGAL NOTICES 14
OGILBY, HUHN & BARR, Attorneys
413 13th St. NW.

UNITED STATES DISTRICT COURT
for the District of Columbia, holding Probate Court, No 111804, Administration. This is to give notice that the subscriber of the District of Columbia has obtained from the Probate Court of the District of Columbia, letters of administration on the estate of Viola I. Barksdale, also known as Viola Allen Barksdale, late of the District of Columbia, deceased. All persons having claims against the deceased are hereby warned to exhibit the same, with the vouchers thereof, legally authenticated, to the subscriber, on or before the 25TH DAY OF FEBRUARY, A.D. 1965; otherwise they may by law be excluded from all benefit of said estate. Given under its hand this 4th day of September, 1964. AMERICAN SECURITY & TRUST COMPANY. By ALFRED T. SOUDER, Trust Officer, Attest: (Seal) ARTHUR P. SMITH, Deputy Register of Wills for the District of Columbia, Clerk of the Probate Court.

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